Amended claims

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**Claims**

1. A plant extract obtainable from red yeast rice comprising one or more statins ~~and being substantially free of polar compounds~~, wherein said plant extract is obtainable by removing one or more polar compounds, which affect the pharmacokinetics of a drug in a subject, from said red yeast rice by a method comprising exposing said red yeast rice to an aqueous solution to remove said polar compounds, wherein said exposure is undertaken for 3 to 36 hours at a temperature of 20-60°C, wherein said method removes at least 70% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein preferably said method removes at least 80% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein more preferably said method removes at least 95% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein preferably said aqueous solution is water.

~~2. The plant extract as claimed in claim 1 wherein said polar compounds affect pharmacokinetics of a drug in a subject.~~

~~3~~2. The plant extract as claimed in claim 1 ~~or claim 2~~, wherein said one or more statins are naturally occurring statins selected from the group consisting of lovastatin, simvastatin, pravastatin and mevastatin, wherein preferably the ~~one or more naturally occurring statins~~ lovastatin ~~are~~ is selected from one or more monacolins, wherein preferably the one or more monacolins are selected from the group consisting of monacolin K, monacolin J, monacolin L and monacolin M, wherein preferably the monacolin is monacolin K, wherein preferably the monacolin K is present in the plant extract in an amount of 0.2mg-1mg per gram of plant extract.

~~4. The plant extract as claimed in any one of the preceding claims, wherein said plant extract is a product of microbial fermentation.~~

~~5. The plant extract as claimed in any one of the preceding claims, wherein said plant extract is extracted from a plant belonging to the family Poaceae, preferably the plant is a cereal selected from the group consisting of maize, rice, wheat, barley, sorghum, millet, oat, rye, triticale and buckwheat, preferably the cereal is rice, preferably the rice is red yeast rice; or wherein said plant extract is extracted from a plant selected from the family Fabaceae, preferably the plant is a bean from the genus Phaseolus, selected from the group consisting of P. vulgaris, P. filiformis, P. coccineus, P. lunatus, P. maculatus and P. acutifolius; or wherein said plant extract is extracted from a pleurotus fungi, preferably, the pleurotus fungi is pleurotus ostreatus; wherein preferably the monacolin K is present in the plant extract in an amount of about 0.2mg-1mg per gram of extract; wherein preferably at least 80%, preferably 95%, of the polar compounds are removed from said extract.~~

~~6~~3. A method of preparing an extract from red yeast rice comprising one or more statins, said method comprising ~~the step of~~ removing one or more polar compounds which affect pharmacokinetics of a drug in a subject from said red yeast rice by exposing said red yeast rice to an aqueous solution to remove said polar compounds, wherein said exposure is undertaken for 8 to 36 hours at a temperature of 20-60°C, wherein said method removes at least 70% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein preferably said method removes at least 80% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein more preferably said method removes at least 95% of the polar compounds from said red yeast rice, wherein preferably said aqueous solution is water. ~~from a plant material wherein said plant material contains one or more statins, preferably, wherein the plant material is solid plant matter.~~

~~7. The method as claimed in claim 6 wherein said one or more polar compounds affect pharmacokinetics of a drug in a subject.~~

~~8~~4. The method as claimed in claim ~~6 or claim 7~~3, further comprising the step of removing one or more toxins from the ~~plant material~~red yeast rice prior to the step of removing said one or more polar compounds, ~~preferably,~~ wherein the one or more toxins are removed by exposing the ~~plant material~~red yeast rice to a solvent selected to dissolve said one or more toxins, preferably~~,~~ ~~wherein the solvent for dissolving said one or more toxins is slightly acidic, preferably,~~ wherein the pH of the solvent for dissolving said one or more toxins is between ~~about~~ 5 to less than 7, preferably wherein the solvent comprises a salt of an alkaline metal, preferably~~,~~ wherein the salt is selected from the group consisting of sodium phosphate, sodium acetate and sodium bicarbonate.~~,~~

5. The method as claimed in claim 3 or 4, wherein ~~preferably, wherein~~ an organic acid is also present in said solvent for dissolving said one or more toxins, preferably~~,~~ wherein the organic acid is a carboxylic acid.

~~9~~6. The method as claimed in claim ~~8~~4 or 5, wherein the toxin removal step comprises the step of removing citrinin.~~, preferably, wherein said method comprises the step of exposing the solid plant material to an aqueous solution to remove said polar compounds, preferably, wherein said exposing the solid plant material to an aqueous solution is undertaken for 8-36 hours at a temperature of 20-60°C; said method preferably~~

7. The method as claimed in any one of claims 3 to 6 comprising the step of forming a liquid extract from said ~~solid plant material~~red yeast rice, ~~preferably,~~ wherein the step of forming the liquid extract comprises the step of exposing the ~~solid plant material~~red yeast rice to an organic solution, preferably~~,~~ wherein the organic solution is selected from the group consisting of alcohols, ethers, haloforms, ketones and alkylene glycol, preferably~~,~~ wherein the organic solution comprises an organic compound that is miscible with water, preferably, wherein the organic solution comprises at least 50% organic compound in a water solvent, preferably~~,~~ wherein the organic solution comprises at least 70% organic compound in a water solvent.~~; said method preferably~~

8. The method as claimed in claim 6 or 7 comprising the step of separating said ~~plant material~~red yeast rice from said liquid extract, and evaporating the solvent of said liquid extract to form a dried **plant extract**~~; wherein preferably said extract is a product of microbial fermentation~~.

~~10. The method as claimed in any one of claims 6-9, wherein said extract is extracted from a plant belonging to the family Poaceae, preferably, the plant is a cereal selected from the group consisting of maize, rice, wheat, barley, sorghum, millet, oat, rye, triticale and buckwheat, preferably the cereal is rice, preferably, the rice is red yeast rice; or wherein said plant extract is extracted from a plant selected from the family Fabaceae, preferably, the plant is a bean from the genus Phaseolus, selected from the group consisting 5 of P. vulgaris, P. filiformis, P. coccineus, P. lunatus, P. maculatus and P. acutifolius; or wherein said extract is extracted from a pleurotus fungi, preferably, wherein said pleurotus fungi is pleurotus ostreatus.~~

~~11~~3. The method as claimed in any one of **claims** ~~6-10~~3 to 8, wherein said one or more statins are as defined in claim 2 ~~naturally occurring statins, preferably the one or more naturally occurring statins are selected from one or more monocolins, preferably, the one or more monacolins are selected from the group consisting of monacolin K, monacolin J, monacolin L and monacolin M, preferably, the monacolin is monacolin K, preferably, the monacolin K is present in the extract in an amount of about 0.2mg-1mg per gram of extract; wherein preferably at least 80%, preferably 95%, of the polar compounds are removed from said extract~~.

~~12~~10. A composition or oral dosage form comprising a plant extract as claimed in ~~any one of~~ claims 1~~-5~~ or 2, together with a pharmaceutically acceptable carrier.

~~13~~11. The plant extract as claimed in ~~any one of~~ claim~~s~~ 1~~-5~~ or 2 for use in the treatment or prevention of hyperlipidemia.

12. The plant extract as claimed in claim 1 or 2 for use in the ~~or the~~ reduction of cholesterol in a subject.

13. The plant extract as claimed in claim 1 or 2 for use in ~~or~~ the inhibition ~~Of~~ of 3-hydroxy-3-methylglutaryl-coenzyme A (HMG-CoA) reductase in a subject.

14. A packaged dosage form comprising a plant extract of any one of claims 1~~-5~~ or 2 together with instructions for use.

15. The plant extract of claim~~s~~ 1 or 2 wherein said plant extract is a dried plant extract.